would take a couple of hours, but it would take days to reach the plantation hills before the advent of the railways. These migrations were initially male dominated but became more gender-balanced over time to reflect the demand for female labour on tea plantations. They were also over-represented from the lowest castes, especially the Paraiyan caste.[47] From the north-eastern cluster of districts closer to Madras, migrants would head for the region comprising present-day Malaysia with a relatively more mixed caste and religious profile to work in rubber, sugar and oil palm plantations, and other assorted jobs. Towards Burma, Tamil migration was dominated by the Chettiar mercantile caste. World War II and the Japanese occupation of Burma and parts of South East Asia curtailed opportunities for migration. Later, thousands of workers were repatriated from Ceylon as well. These mercantile connections and mass expulsions will be discussed in greater detail in subsequent chapters, but suffice to say that when India re-engaged with the global economy in the late 20th century, Tamil labour outmigration resumed from the same clusters as before and with considerable intensity towards the Gulf countries and to a lesser extent, Malaysia and Singapore.[48]

Upwards on the east coast, after a momentary pause, the memory of historic mass male migration lies in the elevated sex ratios of districts north of the Godavari river basin—Vishakapatnam, Vizianagaram and Srikakulam—in the early 20th century.[49] This region, like Ganjam, was cyclone-prone and set off mass migrations of Telugu-speaking people who would comprise a major part of overseas migration to Burma and also form a small part of the Indian community in Malaya. The majority would work in Rangoon's vast informal economy and send home considerable amounts of money. Migration was important for many lower-caste labourers to improve social and economic mobility.[50] While outmigration involved a mix of castes and was male-dominated, women also went to Burma, working either as domestic helps or prostitutes.[51] Mass outmigration from this region is no longer as intense as it was, partly because of the rise of Vishakapatnam as an important port city in the 20th century. Coastal Andhra migrations towards Hyderabad, and later America, picked up in the second half of the 20th century. This was strongly reflected in Telugu